VeriFlow Guarded Preservation and Sparse Replay of Row Pipelines Across Schema Migration

Sai Mohita.C (Registration No. **24BCE2057**)

Abstract

A schema migration can discard source values while leaving the behavior of a particular data pipeline unchanged. Conversely, a small numeric conversion can change a filter decision even when the pipeline still runs. We present VeriFlow, a compiler and migration prototype for deterministic, typed, row-wise CSV pipelines with derivation, validation, filtering, and projection. Given an explicit one-step schema mapping, VeriFlow identifies observed old fields and derives sufficient preservation rules or executable guards. It compiles bindings from new-schema cells to the existing pipeline VM, then chooses guard admission, selective old-cell retention, or rejection for each migrated row. A persisted bundle records row IDs, field-level guard certificates, retained cells, and replayed typed observations. Terminal-aware execution defers fields used only by projection and omits their old cells when a row filters, rejects, or errors first. On an actual 2021 Malaysian Ministry of Health ICU schema change, 7,315 paired rows show a removed field with nonzero values on 4,060 rows. A pipeline that ignores the removed field is preserved with no retention; a pipeline that selects it retains the removed cell on 4,025 emitted rows and none of the 3,290 filtered rows. All processed observations and all compared post-change rows matched. A separate ten-case synthetic pilot over 5,926 distinct public-data rows admitted 10,379 case-rows and recovered 7,549, with no observed replay mismatch. The guarantee applies to well-typed legacy rows at migration time, not arbitrary future new-schema rows.

Keywords: schema evolution; data pipelines; conditional preservation; guarded migration; provenance; executable replay.

1 Introduction

Schema-change labels describe record reconstruction, but a pipeline only observes some source values and decisions. Suppose `score: decimal` becomes `score: int` by truncation toward zero. A row with score `40.7` changes the truth of `score > 40`, but not `score >= 40`. If the pipeline only filters on `score >= 40` and selects an unchanged `name`, it can preserve its typed observation even though the exact score is lost. A second change may drop an old field that the pipeline never reads, leaving behavior unchanged. If the pipeline selects that field, continued execution instead requires retained information.

VeriFlow asks three questions. **RQ1:** Can a restricted compiler identify when a lossy mapping preserves a specific row pipeline, and state a checkable condition for uncertain values? **RQ2:** Can migration turn that analysis into an executable new-schema input plan that admits, retains, or rejects each row and replays the result from disk? **RQ3:** What admission, retention, and byte costs arise on synthetic stress cases and one documented real schema change?

The contribution is a scoped executable preservation contract. VeriFlow combines dependency-sensitive proof rules, migration-time guard admission, per-field certificates, terminal-aware retention of projection-only cells, and persisted replay. It also reports a collision when two distinct old rows have the same migrated row but different old observations. The system uses explicit mappings; it does not infer a migration, rewrite a textual new `.vfl` program, or prove behavior for new rows that did not originate from checked old rows.

2 Model and preservation contract

A legacy schema defines typed fields. A VeriFlow pipeline orders `let`, `require`, and `keep` operations before `select`. Its VM evaluates exact rational numeric values, text values, and Boolean expressions. For a well-typed old row `s`, `Obs(P,s)` is one of: emitted selected typed values in order; filtered; rejected with its validation message; or expression error with its error class. An executed `let` matters even when unselected because its expression can fail. This observation model excludes the original lexical spelling of CSV cells and malformed-input handling.

Let `F` be a defined explicit forward mapping from old to new rows. Let `E` be the compiled evolved execution plan: new-schema field bindings followed by the legacy VM instructions. For each field that an executed operation or selected output can observe, the compiler supplies either exact reconstruction, a sufficient guard checked on `s`, or a retained old cell. A row accepted by the migration command satisfies:

```
Obs(P, s) = Obs(E, F(s), retained(s), certified(s))
```

Here `certified(s)` names guarded bindings whose guards passed on the old row; `retained(s)` supplies old values for required fields whose guard failed or whose source field was dropped. A field-level certificate matters when one guard passes and another fails on the same row. Certificates are migration assertions stored in the bundle, not proofs that a later arbitrary new-schema row satisfies a guard. The bundle uses unkeyed digests to detect accidental inconsistency; it is not an authenticated record against an attacker who can rewrite the whole bundle.

VeriFlow reports preserved when the sufficient condition is universal on its stated domain, conditional when a guard is required, breaking when a replayed old-row collision shows a new-row-only deterministic program cannot preserve both observations, and unknown when no supported rule or collision decides the case. Absence of a bounded witness never establishes preservation.

2 1 Sufficient rules

Rule	Scope and argument
Exact reconstruction	Same-type copy/rename and int to decimal reconstruct the same typed source value.
Unused source	A dropped or changed field outside the transitive dependencies of executed operations and selected outputs cannot affect Obs on a well-typed row.
Positive integer threshold	For finite decimal x and integer k >= 1, truncation toward zero preserves x >= k and x < k; pointwise preservation extends through supported Boolean composition.
Threshold-gap guard	For one affected atomic x > k or x <= k, the truth value changes exactly when k < x < k+1. The guard admits values outside this interval. Conjoined guards are sufficient, not generally optimal, for compound expressions.
Integral fallback	If an old decimal is integral, decimal-to-integer conversion reconstructs its exact typed value. This covers selected values and operations outside the narrower threshold rule.
Text split/merge guards	The guard checks the actual round trip of the defined split or merge operator. For split without a delimiter occurrence, the empty second part causes reverse joining to append a delimiter, so that case needs retention.

The exact-value argument follows induction over ordered VM operations: unchanged inputs give unchanged derived values, short-circuit choices, validation outcomes, filtering decisions, and selected outputs. The threshold rule follows from the integer intervals on each side of positive k. Division-sensitive derivations fall back to exact integral reconstruction because truncation can change a nonzero denominator into zero. An observed dropped field without retention remains unknown or breaking; the system does not turn a missing value into a valid old value.

3 System design

The existing compiler lexes and parses a .vfl pipeline, checks types, builds intermediate operations, and runs a VM. A separate evolution parser and compiler classify explicit copy, rename, conversion, add, drop, split, and merge mappings. Impact analysis follows source-field dependencies through derived expressions and executed conditions. compile-evolved generates an EvolvedProgram with new-schema input fields, bindings for observed old fields, guard/recovery requirements, and the existing VM bytecode. The bindings fill VM register names; this is a compiled new-schema input plan rather than a textual source-to-source rewrite.

migrate-run reads each old row once, validates its cells, evaluates guards before lossy conversion, and migrates it. In sparse mode it retains a dropped observed field or a guarded field whose guard fails. It now distinguishes old fields loaded by any VM operation from old fields used only by final projection. The executor conservatively binds all operation fields, executes operations in order, and binds projection-only fields only if the row emits. When the old row filters, rejects, or produces an expression error first, sparse mode omits projection-only old cells. Such rows remain labeled recovered with an empty sidecar when a static guard or drop prevented universal admission; this retains the ledger's proof meaning. For other guarded fields on the same recovered row, it saves field-level certificates. Guard-only mode rejects rows needing retention under the static proof; full-row mode retains every old source field. Each accepted row gets a UUID within the bundle. The bundle stores migrated.csv, ledger.jsonl, sidecar.jsonl, program.json, manifest.json, replay.jsonl, rejects, and a summary. replay-migration loads the persisted plan without original source or mapping files, verifies paired row IDs and digests, and executes from new cells plus retained old cells. A mismatch with the original typed observation aborts bundle publication.

The compiler review uncovered a mixed-guard defect in an earlier version: a recovered row was treated as if all its guards had failed, so it could reject a valid row when only one field needed retention. The implemented field-level certificate fixes this case. A regression uses a = 41.7, b = 40.7, two strict-threshold guards, and a decimal-to-integer conversion; it retains only b and replays the row. Further tests cover terminal projection omission, a field also loaded by an operation, validation rejection, expression error, and source-free replay.

4 Evaluation design

We evaluate three existing strategies: **sparse** (admit or selectively retain), **guard-only** (admit or reject), and **full-row** (retain all declared old cells). A schema-level loss label and a dependency-only checker are diagnostic internal ablations, not competing research systems. We report counts, retained cells, sidecar bytes, total bundle bytes, three-run median end-to-end runtime, and typed-observation mismatches. The timings include analysis, migration, file writing, and disk replay. A guard-only run that rejects rows does less work, so its runtime is not an isolated guard overhead.

4 1 Versioned real schema change

The Malaysian Ministry of Health public repository versions the ICU CSV. The 22 July 2021 commit removes vent_sari and renames four beds_icu* fields to bed_icu*. We use its immediate parent and the changed commit as the paired versions. The included projections retain date, state, the relevant bed count, vent_covid, and the old vent_sari. A verifier pins both original Git blobs and both projected SHA-256 hashes, checks 7,315 unique (date,state) pairs, and checks that every actual post-change projected row equals the rename-and-drop mapping of its old counterpart. The removed value is nonzero on 4,060 old rows. This is observed schema and data history, while the two tested pipeline definitions are ours rather than reported Ministry applications.

The **preserved** pipeline filters on vent_covid > 0 and selects date, state, and the renamed bed count. It never reads the dropped field, so it should require no retention. The **recovered** pipeline applies the same filter and selects date, state, and dropped vent_sari; it should retain that old cell only for rows that reach projection. For both, we check each accepted migrated row against the actual official post-change projection and compare replayed typed observations with old execution. These two workloads reuse the same 7,315 source rows and are never counted as independent records.

4 2 Synthetic stress and controls

Ten explicit injected changes over UCI Abalone, Iris, and Red Wine Quality reuse 5,926 distinct source rows across 17,928 case-rows. They cover safe and strict decimal-to-integer thresholds, selected changed values, and a guarded text split. Eight predeclared negative controls probe validation, derived expressions, expression errors, observed drops, unsupported conversion, and Boolean combinations. Four CSV parity checks compare outputs and rejects on guard-admitted rows. An observed-drop collision control and a two-row NYC311 field-addition reenactment are reported separately. NYC311 uses experimental defaults and is not treated as an official migrated snapshot.

All final integrated runs used Python 3.12.14 on Windows. The full test suite passed 107 tests. The integrated study runs each strategy three times per case and records medians. The raw results and exact commands are in evaluation/.

5 Results

5 1 Real paired history

Pipeline and strategy	Admitted	Recovered	Rejected	Old cells retained
Preserved / sparse	7,315	0	0	0
Preserved / guard-only	7,315	0	0	0
Preserved / full-row	0	7,315	0	36,575
Recovered / sparse	0	7,315	0	4,025
Recovered / guard-only	0	0	7,315	0
Recovered / full-row	0	7,315	0	36,575

Pipeline and strategy	Sidecar bytes	Bundle bytes	Actual after rows checked	Typed mismatches
Preserved / sparse	0	2,682,667	7,315	0
Preserved / guard-only	0	2,682,675	7,315	0
Preserved / full-row	1,728,544	4,872,070	7,315	0
Recovered / sparse	1,088,711	4,228,322	7,315	0
Recovered / guard-only	0	861,957	0	not applicable
Recovered / full-row	1,728,544	4,868,160	7,315	0

Every compared new row also matched the actual post-change projection. For the recovered pipeline, terminal-aware sparse mode retains vent_sari on the 4,025 emitted rows and no old cell on the 3,290 filtered rows. That is 45.0% fewer old cells than the previous static sparse plan and 89.0% fewer than full-row retention. The saved empty sidecar entries for filtered rows keep the recovered-mode ledger semantics, so sidecar bytes fall by only 4.6% against the previous sparse plan. Against full-row retention, sidecar bytes fall by 37.0% and total bundle bytes by 13.1%. The guard-only recovered case rejects every row, so its small bundle and zero replay mismatches are not preservation evidence for those rows. On the preserved pipeline, sparse mode requires no sidecar despite a genuinely dropped source field.

The three-run median times for the real preserved case were 650 ms sparse and 800 ms full-row. For the real recovered case they were 830 ms sparse and 885 ms full-row. These are descriptive single-host measurements; no statistical significance or general speedup is claimed.

5 2 Injected pilot

Strategy	Admitted	Recovered	Rejected	Old cells retained	Sidecar bytes	Typed mismatches
Sparse	10,379	7,549	0	7,549	1,221,174	0
Guard-only	10,379	0	7,549	0	0	0
Full-row	0	17,928	0	53,784	3,452,534	0

The pilot's 17,928 case-rows reuse 5,926 distinct rows; they are not 17,928 independent observations. Three record-lossy but pipeline-preserving numeric cases pass without guard restrictions. Strict-threshold guards admit 2,782/4,177 Abalone, 99/150 Iris, and 1,214/1,599 Red Wine rows. The observed-drop two-row control shows different old selected values after both old rows collide into the same new row; sparse retention restores both. These checks support the scoped implementation, while the synthetic changes cannot establish prevalence in real histories.

6 Related work

Awiti, Wrembel, and Zimányi (2025) repair ETL processes affected by source schema changes using extended relational algebra and operator-specific repair rules. VeriFlow addresses the narrower question of preserving typed row observations under an explicit mapping, including value-dependent guards, selective retention, and paired replay. It does not claim general ETL repair as new. Kramer, Restat, and Störl (2025) analyze operator robustness and propose directions for self-adaptive cleaning pipelines; our executable pilot studies one limited operator fragment rather than implementing their broader vision.

Auge and Heuer (2022) use provenance to enhance inversion of schema evolution, so storing auxiliary source information is established prior art. VeriFlow's contribution is the binding of such retained values to a pipeline-specific preservation decision and replay bundle. Vassiliadis et al. (2023) study schema and source histories across 195 projects, motivating explicit real-history evaluation. EvoSchema (2025) benchmarks schema-evolution robustness for text-to-SQL systems; its task and metrics are different, but its diversity of schema perturbations underscores the narrowness of our one-change real study. We do not claim conditional equivalence, selected-information preservation, or schema rewriting as concepts invented here.

Ortín, Hoyos, and García-Molina (2026 preprint) generate trace-driven relational-to-document migrations through a unified schema model and evaluate query-result equivalence, including joins and aggregations, at a much larger scale. Thus, preservation of query behavior after migration is not a unique VeriFlow claim. Our distinct scoped question is whether an explicitly lossy mapping preserves a particular typed row pipeline, and which old cells or migration-time guard certificates suffice when it does not. We have no direct implementation baseline against their system, and our one-event evaluation is materially narrower.

7 Threats to validity and limits

The theorem concerns finite, well-typed legacy rows with defined mappings and migration-time access to their original values. The compiled input plan fills legacy VM registers; it is not a standalone textual rewritten pipeline. New-only future rows have no old-row guard certificate, so the result does not certify their behavior. The language excludes joins, aggregation, arbitrary UDFs, and multi-step migrations. Guard conjunction can conservatively retain rows whose full compound expression would actually remain unchanged. Terminal-aware omission applies only to fields absent from every VM operation and used solely by final projection; operation inputs are retained conservatively even when a row stops before a later operation. Sparse retention is sufficient, not globally minimal.

The Malaysian case is one real drop-and-rename event with two experimental pipelines, not a sample of organizational production pipelines. Its official paired data give stronger external evidence than an injected mutation, but one event cannot establish generality. The other ten cases use injected changes over reused rows. The reported zero mismatches are observed finite-study results, not an empirical proof of the universal rules; the rule arguments carry the scoped claim. Runtime medians use three repetitions on one Windows machine and include different amounts of work by strategy. Byte totals depend on JSONL and CSV serialization and UUID lengths. The bundle's unkeyed hashes detect accidental corruption but do not provide adversarial authentication or stable source identity across migrations.

8 Reproducibility and conclusion

From the repository root with Python 3.12 or later:

```
python -m evaluation.real_history.prepare_moh_icu
```

```
python -m unittest discover -s tests -q
python -m evaluation.migration_study
python -m evaluation.freeze_manifest
```

The first command verifies included projections without downloading data; --fetch regenerates them from pinned official commits when network access is available. The study writes evaluation/migration-results.json; the manifest hashes code, case definitions, data, and results. compile-evolved, migrate-run, and replay-migration provide a direct CLI demonstration, as specified in the method note.

VeriFlow makes a limited but executable claim: a lossy source schema change need not change a specific pipeline's observations, and when it does remove information the system can retain observed cells and replay a migrated bundle. The real paired ICU history demonstrates both paths on the same documented change. Broader schema classes, arbitrary future-row guarantees, and independent multi-organization evaluation remain open.

References

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Appendix A Artifact details

The actual historical comparison uses the parent commit 3b56bc326306a013d1fb26eb4f33084f432b4b4c and changed commit 4e80229047d796f14c7aac82910a3377277b699f. The corresponding official epidemic/icu.csv Git blob hashes are f8bd4e11746df2109807e7a1f0261982b4605564 and bc45a1fa903e0b5ec32ccb7a6ca0b37436e10a37. The included projected CSV SHA-256 values are b8a0d35cc73b45f6b9367f67472ee2fbc01559993185ce55694317d2d0f651f6 before and 2cd79c6da5e714153456ee743d8f6d2925c2b108b4997ffa0690215911036be6 after. The projection script verifies the source Git blobs when run with --fetch and checks all 7,315 date/state pairs in its ordinary offline mode.

The real preserved pipeline's three-run median times were 650 ms sparse, 658 ms guard-only, and 800 ms full-row. The real recovered pipeline's medians were 830 ms sparse, 179 ms guard-only, and 885 ms full-row. The 179 ms guard-only run rejected all 7,315 rows, so that timing is not a comparable throughput result. The counted bundle bytes include the new-schema CSV, ledger, persisted program, sidecar, replay, rejects, manifest, and summary. Source and case files are outside that bundle measurement. A repeated study run generates new UUIDs, but the measured file lengths and counts are checked for agreement across repetitions.

The direct regression for mixed guards is in tests/test_migration.py. It checks a recovered row with one certified field and one retained field, then removes the certificate and verifies that source-free replay refuses the incomplete bundle. Four terminal-aware tests check filtered, rejected, and expression-error outcomes, a field read by an operation, and a failed guard on an unused projection. The full suite's 107 passing tests include compiler, optimizer, evolution, impact, recovery, migration, runtime, and CLI checks. This is an implementation check, separate from the formal sufficiency arguments and finite dataset comparisons.